Chapter 1: The Broken Pane

The glasshouse at Fernley Hall had four hundred and twelve panes, and on the morning after the first frost one of them was broken from the inside.

Joan Ashby, who had kept the hothouse for nine winters, swept up the pieces before the gardeners arrived. She told herself it was the cold. Glass did strange things in the cold. But the shards lay outward on the gravel path, and there were no footprints in the frost but her own.

Chapter 2: The Orange Tree

At the centre of the glasshouse stood an orange tree older than the Hall itself. It had not fruited in living memory. The family kept it out of stubbornness, and Joan kept it alive out of something closer to affection.

That week it flowered. Small white blossoms opened along every branch, and the whole glasshouse smelled of a summer that was months away. Joan wrote the date in her ledger and underlined it twice.

Chapter 3: Lady Fernley's Visit

Lady Fernley came down from the house in her fur-lined boots and stood beneath the tree for a long time without speaking.

"My grandmother said it would bloom again," she said at last, "when someone came home who had been away too long."

Joan said nothing. That evening, walking back to her cottage, she saw a light in the old coach house, where no one had lived for twenty years.